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The graduation ceremony and the announcement represent a significant effort to spark enthusiasm for entrepreneurship in South Africa. According to the latest Global Entrepreneurship Monitor South Africa Report released in February, fewer people than ever before are considering starting new businesses. Business startups have declined to their lowest level since before the 2020 coronavirus pandemic.



THE LATEST GLOBAL ENTREPRENEURSHIP

The latest Global Entrepreneurship Monitor South Africa Report, released in February, paints a concerning picture. After reaching an all-time high of 20 percent between 2021 and 2022, the percentage of adults aged 16-64 intending to start a new business in the next three years declined to 10% in 2023, the lowest in 20 years. Total entrepreneurial activity (TEA) also declined from a pandemic high of 17.5% to 8.5% in 2022/23, below the 2019 level of 11%. Established business ownership almost halved, from 3.5% in 2019 to 1.8% in 2022/23, after an encouraging peak of 5.2% in the pandemic years.

After overcoming initial challenges in establishing the school in South Africa, Dr. Thomas proudly shares there are some amazing rags-to-riches stories of JBS alumni. Some of these successful entrepreneurs will be present at the ceremony to share their inspiring personal journeys.

Dr. Thomas emphasized that the success of the school and its students is rooted in its unique approach. The school stands out because it teaches entrepreneurs how to grow their businesses using Biblical principles. Accredited by Services SETA (Services Sector Education and Training Authority) and with a faculty of industry experts, the school is just getting started, she said

Dr. Thomas said the Biblical scripture Ezekiel 36:35 best explains Dr. Winston's vision for entrepreneurs

transforming the most downtrodden neighborhoods. "And they shall say, 'This land that was desolate has become like the Garden of Eden, and the waste and desolate and ruined cities have become fortified and are inhabited.'" She believes entrepreneurs have the vision; they need help.

"I tell my team, we are midwives," Dr. Thomas said. "We bring these babies (businesses) and the visions these entrepreneurs have to make a difference in their communities into full term and to full birth because

they do not have anyone to help them nurture and grow their ideas. The Joseph Business School believes entrepreneurialism is a key factor to economic growth, and entrepreneurs' ideas are key to any economy becoming a thriving economy. When you look at particularly Black and brown communities that are under-resourced and under-financed, you see a great divide as far as wealth, poverty, and violence. Dr. Winston says, "Poverty is not caused by a lack of resources but rather a lack of self-production." We believe we can